



On the argument for (and against) neuropsychanalysis

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To cite this article: Larry S. Sandberg (2016) On the argument for (and against) neuropsychanalysis, *The International Journal of Psychoanalysis*, 97:4, 1149-1150, DOI: [10.1111/1745-8315.12560](https://doi.org/10.1111/1745-8315.12560)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1111/1745-8315.12560>



Published online: 31 Dec 2017.



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On the argument for (and against) neuropsych psychoanalysis

Dear Editor,

I read with interest the recent contributions of Yovell, Solms and Fotopoulou (2015) and the response of Blass and Carmeli (2015). Blass and Carmeli are particularly critical of the clinical material pointing out the supportive nature of the intervention. They also argue that the familiar psychological finding regarding the fallibility of memory relegates the neuroscientific research to no more than a biological correlate of what is common knowledge amongst psychoanalysts. Blass and Carmeli (2007) previously observed that the importance of focusing on recollecting facts of past events in treatment was a ‘debated issue’ with the trend in contemporary practice supporting a more limited role for such approaches. I offer a brief vignette illustrating the use of neuro-scientific research on traumatic memory during the course of a four time per week analysis. I argue that such research can be relevant and helpful, though, in ways that are neither categorical nor predictable.

Many years ago as a candidate I struggled in my work with an adult analysand whose belief her mother had sexually abused her in certain ways as a young child allowed her to feel integrated as ‘victim’. The focus in supervision was on working with her ‘psychic reality’ – the analysand’s experience reflecting some admixture of fantasy and historical reality. In the transference, the experience of victimization was enacted when attempting to explore her reality as over-determined by internal and external factors. Attempts to explore what she believed happened left her feeling criticized and attacked as she had been in childhood – my efforts were equated with either my disbelief or thinking she was ‘stupid’ as her father had called her.

At the time, I was reading about the neuro-scientific research on memory and trauma (specifically hippocampal damage due to early trauma impacted declarative memory systems). It served an unintended supervisory function in helping me see that the clinical surface demanded an exploration of *how* she remembered (with conviction) rather than *what* she remembered. It helped me see that I had unconsciously become the container for an uncertainty she had split off. The research (which raised questions about what could be explicitly remembered from childhood abuse) helped me formulate what otherwise had escaped me (and my supervisor). Interpreting her certainty as a defense helped bring the patient’s deeply shameful and guilt provoking pedophilic urges into the treatment. The interpretation made no reference to her brain or brain research. We could now look at her wish to victimize others including me.

Blass and Carmeli (2007, p. 23) have commented on how the focus on reconstruction has given way to heightened attention on the “patient’s tendencies to recollect in a certain way” in the setting of transference. This is precisely what happened for me – a *consequence* of reading the neuro-scientific research on memory. It is plausible that the contemporary trend they

observe has been influenced, in part, by the very research they deem irrelevant or dangerous. This is a position taken up by Leuzinger-Bohleber (2008, p. 1165) who cautions against throwing ‘the baby out with the bath water’ with regard to reconstruction.

Is neuroscience relevant to psychoanalysis? Here was a neuroscientific fact (Bremner *et al.*, 1997) that helped me understand my analysand’s mind and the transference countertransference situation. It informed my interpretation of defense and deepened the analytic process. I am arguing for relevance, not necessity. Other fledgling candidates, perhaps with a different supervisor, would have arrived at an understanding of the analysand’s mind without recourse to memory research. In addition, the memory research, however consonant with analytic trends, is not the final word on reconstruction.

The categorical position of Blass and Carmeli that neuroscience has ‘complete’ irrelevance for psychoanalysis (and endangers it) distinguishes it from other interdisciplinary efforts with philosophy, humanities, art, and religion that have long enriched our field. While I see many of the concerns they raise as legitimate, the conviction with which Blass and Carmeli (2015) embrace their point of view blinds them (yes, in my eyes) to the complexity of the situation and creates an unfortunate antagonism. I believe there are unique challenges that exist in relating neuroscience to psychoanalysis but the authors’ conclusion is, at best, premature.

It may be, as Blass and Carmeli suggest, that the artist is not helped by knowledge of the chemistry of the paints she uses. And it may be that knowing about the brain’s functioning is unnecessary and, at times, interferes with exploring the analysand’s mind. But if I am neither the artist nor the chemist but one engaged in the restoration of art then knowing chemistry may come in handy at times.

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